

SENATE JOINT RESOLUTION 987

By Stevens

A RESOLUTION to honor and commend Robert Taswell "Tas" Gardner, president of the Tennessee District Public Defenders Conference.

WHEREAS, it is fitting that the members of this General Assembly should salute those Tennesseans who, through their extraordinary efforts and diligent service to their fellow citizens, have distinguished themselves as community leaders of whom we can all be proud; and

WHEREAS, one such noteworthy individual is Robert Taswell "Tas" Gardner of Paris, 2025-2026 president of the Tennessee District Public Defenders Conference (TDPDC), who has rendered sterling service during his presidential term; and

WHEREAS, as TDPDC president, Mr. Gardner has been the principal executive officer for supervising and controlling the business and affairs of the Conference while also assisting the Conference in advising the General Assembly regarding legislation to improve the criminal justice system; and

WHEREAS, Tas Gardner has served with the 24th Judicial District Public Defender's Office, encompassing Benton, Carroll, Decatur, Hardin, and Henry counties, since 1992, first as an investigator, then as assistant public defender, and finally in his current role of public defender, which he assumed in 2017 after being appointed by Governor Bill Haslam; and

WHEREAS, a member of the Henry County Bar Association and the Tennessee Association of Criminal Defense Lawyers, Mr. Gardner holds degrees from Columbia State Community College and the University of Tennessee at Martin, and he earned his Doctorate of Jurisprudence in 2008 from Nashville School of Law; and

WHEREAS, a respected leader in his field, Mr. Gardner served as a member of the Board of Judicial Conduct from 2012 to 2015, helping review complaints filed against judges; and

WHEREAS, Tas Gardner is also devoted to serving his community as a member of the Tennessee River Longbeards Committee and the Paris Henry County Ducks Unlimited Committee, chairman of the Paris Henry County Ducks Unlimited Sponsor Program, and elected board member of the Springville Waterfowl Association; and

WHEREAS, he is a former board member of the Tennessee National Wild Turkey Federation and previously served the Springville Waterfowl Association as vice president and president; and

WHEREAS, Mr. Gardner epitomizes the spirit and commitment that are characteristic of a true Tennessean; and

WHEREAS, we find it appropriate to acknowledge and applaud Mr. Gardner for his dedication to serving the people of this State; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE SENATE OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES CONCURRING, that we honor and commend Robert Taswell "Tas" Gardner, 2025-2026 president of the Tennessee District Public Defenders Conference, as his exemplary term comes to a close, extending our best wishes for his continued success.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy and upon proper request made to the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear without House or Senate designation.